

HISTORY OF TEA

Since its discovery in Asia, tea has traveled the world, gaining popularity everywhere. Yet this beverage, known to revive mind and body, has had a tumultuous history, precipitating revolutions and causing wars.



Pu'er cakes

DISCOVERY OF TEA

It is believed that tea was discovered in China in 2737BCE by Emperor Shennong. While resting under a tea tree, he noticed the aroma from leaves that had fallen into a bubbling kettle. Intrigued by the fragrance, he took a sip and found the liquor refreshing.

2737BCE

Emperor Shennong discovers tea

Tang scholar
Lu Yu



ON THE MOVE

During the Tang Dynasty (618–907), Buddhist monks from Japan and Korea took Chinese tea seeds home and planted them. The monks in those countries nurtured a tea culture that is still in practice today.

760–762

The Tang scholar Lu Yu writes *Cha Ching*, The Book of Tea

828

Tea seeds reach Korea and are planted on Jiri mountain, near Hwagae village on the southern tip of Korea

TEA TIMELINE

420CE

Buddhist monks use tea leaves during meditation

618–907

The ancient Tea Horse Road, established during the Tang Dynasty, links the tea-producing areas of Yunnan with tea-consuming regions across China and Tibet

CULTIVATION

By 420CE, Zen Buddhist monks in China were using tea leaves to stay focused during their meditations. They grew tea plants near the monasteries, processed the tea into cakes, and sold it to locals. In time, farmers learned to grow and process tea, and tea drinking became a part of daily life.

TRADE ROUTES

The Tea Horse Road, shown here in red, was established to connect China to Mongolia and Tibet. The Chinese used this route to barter tea (pressed into cakes) in exchange for strong horses, which they needed for transportation and warfare.

